The Plane Truth

By Ellen DeGeneres

NARRATOR: **(Pg 28-34)** I know that the experts say you're more likely to get hurt crossing the street than you are flying (these, of course, would be the street-crossing experts), but that doesn't make me feel any less frightened of flying. If anything, it makes me **more** afraid of crossing the street. As soon as the light turns green, I run across the street as fast as I can, screaming like a mad *person.* I arrive on the other side out of breath, wheezing, and clutching my stomach.

INTRODUCTION

Many people have a fear of flying. And the Flight Attendant's spiel before take-off doesn't inspire a great deal of confidence either!

(Presented in a friendly, flight attendant voice with accompanying gestures)
Welcome aboard Flight 245. To operate your seat belt, insert the metal tab into the buckle, and pull tight. It works just like every other seat belt, and if you don't know how to operate one, you probably shouldn't be out in public unsupervised.

In the event of a sudden loss of cabin pressure, masks will descend from the ceiling. Stop screaming, grab the mask, and pull it over your face. If you have a small child traveling with you, secure your mask before assisting with theirs. If you are traveling with more than one small child, pick your favorite.

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NARRATOR: I felt edgy the moment I stepped into the aircraft. That could be why I snapped at the woman in front of me. In my defense, she **did** ask the flight attendant a pretty stupid question:

WOMAN IN 27-B (also a nun): Excuse me, where is seat 27-B?

NARRATOR: I mean, really. But I see now that I overreacted when I screamed at her, "Well, moron you walk in the only direction you can, and it's the 27th row seat B – next to seat A. All righty?!" That sort of response is probably one of the many reasons why I'm not a flight attendant. It was only when the woman (27-B) turned around to look at me that I saw she

was a nun. I guess that sort of hat-like thing she wore on her head should have given me a clue. *(beat)* I tried to apologize by smiling and giving her a playful punch on the arm to let her know I was joking. Well, either my playful punch carried more of a wallop than I intended or her advanced years made her frailer than she appeared, but the nun shouted out,

WOMAN IN 27-B (also a nun): Owww! *(rubbing her arm in pain . . . she rolls up her sleeve)*

NARRATOR: . . . you know, that bruise could easily have been there before I hit her. *(beat)* My good friend Jasmine told me that a good way to combat fear is to chant. So all the way to my seat I was chanting, "I'm going to die, I'm going to die, oh sweet Lord, I'm going to die." It didn't work. If anything, I was **more** petrified when I got to my seat (27-A). Even seeing the familiar face of the nun in 27-B (who seemed to flinch when she saw me) didn't call me down.

So here I am, sitting in my seat. *(taking calming breaths, then reacts violently to a sound)* ARGHHH! What was that? We're going to crash!!! Oh, I wish I hadn't shouted that out loud. It was just the beverage cart. *(to seatmate)* "Pardon me, Sister, I am sorry, I . . . . I was frightened. Pray for me." Now she's going to turn on that little air thing above her. Maybe I'm paranoid, but I think it takes power away from the plane somehow. "Sister, don't use that, that's . . . . Dang! Shut if off! Shut it off!" *(beat)* The nun just left to find a different seat. Some people are so touchy. I'm sure she didn't learn that little hand gesture in her convent, either.

I've got to relax somehow. Why didn't I think of this sooner? I'll recline my seat. Oh, that makes all the difference. That ¾ of an inch between upright and reclined is the difference between agony and ecstasy. I never thought ¾ of an inch could mean so much. When I get home, I'm going to put some gizmo in my chairs so that they go back ¾ of an inch, too. I'd better not get too comfortable in my ¾-of-an-inch recline because toward the end of the flight, the flight attendant is going to say,

FLIGHT ATTENDANT: You're going to have to put your seat in the upright position for landing.

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NARRATOR: They're so adamant about that every single time, like that's gonna make a difference. Because if we crash, the investigators are going to say,

INVESTIGATOR: Oh, that's a shame, her seat was recline ¾ of an inch. When will they learn? What was that – 30,000 feet? She could have made that. Sheesh. If only she'd been upright.

NARRATOR: Being reclined isn't working. I'm still freaking out. I know what I need. "Oh, flight attendant. Oh ma'am." *(to audience)* You have to talk nice to the flight attendants because they all have this attitude. And they can afford to have the attitude, because they have the power – they have the peanuts. They have these six peanuts that we need. Six peanuts. Somebody could offer that to you on the street, and you'd say, "I don't want that – get that away from me. Six peanuts? No- oh." Somehow, they've done research. They know that the higher we go, the more we need nuts. And we go crazy if we don't get them. *(to Flight Attendant)* Miss, I didn't get my, uh - - my peanuts. And I'd really appreciate it if you game me some. *(stuffing peanuts one at a time in her mouth)* They're good, aren't they? I've never been able to get them on the ground either. At least not ones this good! *(licking the salt from her fingers)*

(panicked) What was that! We're going to crash! Oops, false alarm. It's just the food card coming down the aisle. We do get excited about it, don't we? "Oh, here comes the cart, put down the tray! La la la la. Put down your tray! They're starting on the other side first. Hurry! Hurry! Those people over there – they're eating. Those people are eating."

Any kind of meat that you get – chicken, steak, anything – has grill marks on each side, like somehow we'll actually believe there's an open-flame grill in the front of the plane. And salads are always two pieces of dead lettuce and salad dressing that comes in that astronaut package. *(package explodes as she tries to open it)* As soon as you open it, it's on your neighbor's lap. "Could I just dip my lettuce, ma'am? Hm, that's a lovely skirt. What is that, silk?" But you know, should that happen, club soda's gonna get that stain our immediately. That's the answer to anything you ask up there, I don't know if you've noticed that.

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NARRATOR: Excuse me, I have an upset stomach.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT: Club soda, be right back.

NARRATOR: Excuse me, I spilled something.

FLIGHT ATTENDANT: Club soda, be right back.

NARRATOR: Ooh, the wing is on fire!

FLIGHT ATTENDANT: Club soda, be right back.

NARRATOR: I thought the food would make me feel less frightened. But it didn't. Maybe if I stretch my legs and go to the restroom it will help. You have no concept of time when you're in there – it's like a casino: no windows, no clocks. I could be the only one to get up out of my seat to go to the bathroom – everybody else is sound asleep when I go – but after I've been in there for what I think is thirty seconds, I open the door and everyone in the plane is lined up, looking at their watches, make me feel like I've been in there forever.

And now I've got to explain the smell that was in there **before** I went in there. "Oh! Listen, there's an odor in there and I didn't do it. It's bad. You might want to sprinkle some club soda, if you uh . . ."

I think my only hope of escaping my mind-numbing fear is to sleep; to sleep and perchance to dream. The only trouble is when I fall asleep on a plane, *(drifts off while finishing this statement)* I always have a nightmare . . . *(only to jolt awake screaming)* Oh sweet Lord, I'm going to die!

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AWARD HISTORY

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